

"Scrolling to Spending: Analyzing Social Media Influence on Purchase Decisions Among Indian College Students Using Regression and Cluster Analysis"

Submitted to

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in specialization

“Business Analytics”

Submitted by

Atharva Fiske

Project Guide

Dr. Deepshree Kumar



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CERTIFICATE

This is to certify that the Thesis on **“SCROLLING TO SPENDING: ANALYZING SOCIAL MEDIA INFLUENCE ON PURCHASE DECISIONS AMONG INDIAN COLLEGE STUDENTS USING REGRESSION AND CLUSTER ANALYSIS”** is a bonafide work of **Atharva Fiske** submitted to the Ramdeobaba University, Nagpur in partial fulfillment IV Semester of MBA. It has been carried out at the School of Management, Ramdeobaba University, Nagpur during the academic year 2025-26.

Date:

Place: Nagpur

Dr Deepshree Kumar

Project Guide

Dr. Chandan Vichoray

Dean, SoM

DECLARATION

I, hereby declare that the project titled “**Scrolling to Spending: Analyzing Social Media Influence on Purchase Decisions Among Indian College Students Using Regression and Cluster Analysis**” submitted herein, has been carried out in the School of Management, Ramdeobaba University, Nagpur. The work is original and has not been submitted earlier as a whole or part for the award of any degree / diploma at this or any other institution / University

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(Roll No.)

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I extend my heartfelt thanks to all the respondents who participated in the survey and provided valuable information for this study.

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Date:

Place:

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CHAPTER 1: INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background

The digital revolution has fundamentally altered the landscape of consumer behaviour across the globe, and India stands at the forefront of this transformation. With a rapidly growing internet penetration rate and an increasingly young population, social media platforms have evolved from mere communication tools into powerful commercial ecosystems. Instagram, YouTube, Facebook, and emerging platforms have become spaces where Indian youth not only consume content but also discover products, evaluate alternatives, and ultimately make purchasing decisions. The phenomenon of scrolling through a social media feed and ending up making a purchase — planned or otherwise — has become a defining characteristic of modern consumer behaviour among Indian college students.

India currently has over 500 million active social media users, a significant proportion of whom fall within the 18 to 29 age bracket. This demographic — college-going youth — represents one of the most commercially valuable and digitally native consumer segments in the country. They are early adopters of trends, highly responsive to peer influence, and spend an average of two to four hours daily on social media platforms. Yet despite their commercial significance, the precise mechanisms through which social media translates into actual purchase decisions remain insufficiently understood in the Indian academic and marketing context.

1.2 Statement of the Problem

While considerable research exists on social media marketing in Western contexts, studies focusing specifically on Indian college students remain limited. Existing research tends to examine social media usage in general terms without distinguishing between the specific factors — such as influencer trust, social proof, and social media attitude — that may individually drive different types of purchase behaviour. Furthermore, most studies treat purchase behaviour as a single outcome, overlooking the important distinction between deliberate purchase intention and unplanned impulse buying. This gap in understanding limits the ability of marketers and brands to design effective, targeted digital marketing strategies for the Indian youth segment.

This study addresses this gap by investigating which specific social media factors significantly predict purchase intention and impulse buying among Indian college students, and whether distinct consumer segments exist within this population based on their social media behaviour and purchase patterns.

1.3 Scope of the Study

This research is scoped to Indian college students between the ages of 18 and 29 years across undergraduate and postgraduate programmes in various fields of study including Commerce and Management, Science and Technology, Arts and Humanities, and Law. The study focuses on five key social media constructs — Social Media Exposure, Influencer Trust, Social Proof, and Social Media Attitude as independent variables, and Purchase Intention and Impulse Buying as dependent variables. Data was collected through a structured online survey administered via Google Forms, yielding 200 complete responses. The geographical scope is pan-Indian, capturing respondents from diverse academic and social backgrounds.

The study does not examine platform-specific behaviour in depth, nor does it track actual transaction data. It relies on self-reported Likert scale responses, which is consistent with established practice in consumer behaviour research.

1.4 Aims and Objectives

The primary aim of this study is to analyse the influence of social media on purchase decisions among Indian college students using quantitative analytical methods. The specific objectives are as follows:

- To identify which social media factors significantly predict Purchase Intention among Indian college students.
- To identify which social media factors significantly predict Impulse Buying among Indian college students.
- To segment Indian college students into distinct consumer groups based on their social media behaviour and purchase patterns using K-Means Cluster Analysis.

1.5 Research Hypotheses

The following hypotheses were formulated to guide the study:

H1: Influencer Trust has a significant positive influence on Purchase Intention and Impulse Buying.

H2: Social Proof has a significant positive influence on Purchase Intention and Impulse Buying.

H3: Social Media Attitude has a significant positive influence on Purchase Intention and Impulse Buying.

1.6 Theoretical Framework

This study is grounded in the Stimulus-Organism-Response (SOR) Model, a well-established theoretical framework in consumer behaviour research. The SOR model posits that external environmental stimuli trigger internal psychological states in an individual, which in turn drive observable behavioural responses. In the context of this study, social media content and exposure serve as the Stimulus, the internal constructs of influencer trust, social proof, and social media attitude constitute the Organism, and purchase intention and impulse buying represent the behavioural Response. This framework provides a theoretically robust foundation for understanding how social media influences the purchase decisions of Indian college students.

1.7 Significance of the Study

This study makes several important contributions to the existing body of knowledge. Academically, it applies a multi-method quantitative approach — combining regression analysis and cluster analysis — to the study of social media influence on consumer behaviour in an Indian context, an area that remains relatively underexplored. Practically, the findings provide actionable insights for brands, digital marketers, and social media managers seeking to effectively engage the Indian college student demographic. By identifying which specific social media factors drive purchase behaviour and which consumer segments exist, the study enables more targeted, efficient, and evidence-based marketing strategies.

For the researcher, this study represents an opportunity to apply Business Analytics tools — including multiple linear regression and K-Means clustering — to a real-world marketing problem with direct commercial relevance, reinforcing the value of data-driven decision-making in contemporary business practice.

1.8 Organisation of the Report

The remainder of this thesis is organised as follows. Chapter 2 presents a comprehensive review of existing literature on social media marketing, consumer behaviour, influencer trust, social proof, and impulse buying. Chapter 3 describes the research methodology including the research design, sampling strategy, data collection instrument, and analytical techniques employed. Chapter 4 presents the data analysis and results. Chapter 5 discusses the key findings in relation to the hypotheses and existing literature. Chapter 6 presents the conclusions, recommendations, and suggestions for future research. Supporting materials including the survey instrument and raw data are provided in the appendices.

CHAPTER 2: LITERATURE REVIEW

1. “Social Media in Marketing: A Review and Analysis of the Existing Literature” – Alalwan et al. (2017)

What did the author study?

The authors studied how social media marketing influences consumer behaviour, brand engagement, and purchase intention across digital platforms.

What were the findings?

The study found that social media advertising and engagement significantly influence consumer purchase intention and brand awareness.

Why is it relevant to this research?

This study supports the idea that social media factors can influence purchase behaviour among Indian college students. It provides theoretical support for analysing social media influence on Purchase Intention.

2. “Influencer Marketing: How Message Value and Credibility Affect Consumer Trust of Branded Content on Social Media” – Lou and Yuan (2019)

What did the author study?

The authors examined how influencer credibility and informational value affect consumer trust and purchase intention on social media.

What were the findings?

The study found that influencer credibility and trust significantly affect consumer purchase intention toward branded products.

Why is it relevant to this research?

This paper supports the inclusion of Influencer Trust as an independent variable in the present study.

3.“The Influence of eWOM in Social Media on Consumers' Purchase Intentions” – Erkan and Evans (2016)

What did the author study?

The study examined how electronic word-of-mouth (eWOM), reviews, and online recommendations influence consumer purchase intention.

What were the findings?

The authors found that social proof elements such as online reviews, peer opinions, and information credibility significantly increase purchase intention.

Why is it relevant to this research?

This study provides strong support for the Social Proof construct used in this research.

4.“Impulse Buying Behaviour: An Online-Offline Comparative and the Impact of Social Media” – Aragoncillo and Orus (2018)

What did the author study?

The authors investigated how social media usage affects impulse buying behaviour among online consumers.

What were the findings?

The study found a significant positive relationship between social media engagement and impulse buying behaviour, especially among young consumers.

Why is it relevant to this research?

This paper supports the study's focus on Impulse Buying as a dependent variable.

5.“Celebrity vs. Influencer Endorsements in Advertising” – Schouten et al. (2020)

What did the author study?

The study compared celebrity influencers and peer influencers in terms of credibility and influence on consumer purchase decisions.

What were the findings?

The authors found that peer influencers generate stronger trust and higher purchase intention due to perceived authenticity.

Why is it relevant to this research?

This study explains how influencer trust and authenticity may affect purchase behaviour among college students.

6.“Social Influence and Online Purchase Intention Among Indian Youth” – Srivastava and Sharma (2018)

What did the author study?

The authors studied how social influence affects online purchase intention among Indian youth consumers.

What were the findings?

The study concluded that peer influence and social proof significantly affect online purchase intention among Indian youth.

Why is it relevant to this research?

This research directly supports the current study’s finding that Social Proof significantly predicts Purchase Intention.

7.“Using the SOR Model to Explore the Impact of Social Commerce on Impulse Buying Behaviour” – Chang et al. (2020)

What did the author study?

The study applied the Stimulus-Organism-Response (SOR) model to understand how social commerce influences impulse buying behaviour.

What were the findings?

The authors found that social media stimuli influence consumer emotions and attitudes, which in turn affect impulse buying behaviour.

Why is it relevant to this research?

This study provides theoretical support for using the SOR framework in the present research.

8.“Segmentation of Indian Social Media Users: Insights for Digital Marketing Strategy” – Banerjee and Bhattacharya (2020)

What did the author study?

The study used cluster analysis to segment Indian social media users based on behaviour and engagement patterns.

What were the findings?

The authors identified multiple consumer segments with different responses to social media marketing strategies.

Why is it relevant to this research?

This paper supports the use of K-Means Cluster Analysis for identifying distinct consumer groups in the present study.

CHAPTER 3: RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

3.1 Research Design

This study adopts a quantitative, cross-sectional research design. A quantitative approach was selected because the study aims to measure the strength and direction of relationships between social media factors and purchase behaviour, test specific hypotheses, and identify consumer segments — all objectives that are best addressed through statistical analysis of numerical data.

The study is descriptive and explanatory in character. It is descriptive insofar as it profiles the demographic characteristics of Indian college students and their social media usage patterns. It is explanatory insofar as it seeks to establish statistical relationships between social media constructs and purchase behaviour outcomes through hypothesis testing.

3.2 Theoretical Framework

The study is grounded in the Stimulus-Organism-Response (SOR) Model. Social media exposure, influencer content, and peer reviews constitute the Stimulus dimension. The internal psychological constructs of Influencer Trust, Social Proof, and Social Media Attitude constitute the Organism dimension. Purchase Intention and Impulse Buying constitute the Response dimension. This framework guided the selection of variables, the design of the measurement instrument, and the formulation of research hypotheses.

The SOR Model Diagram is shown in the figure 3.1

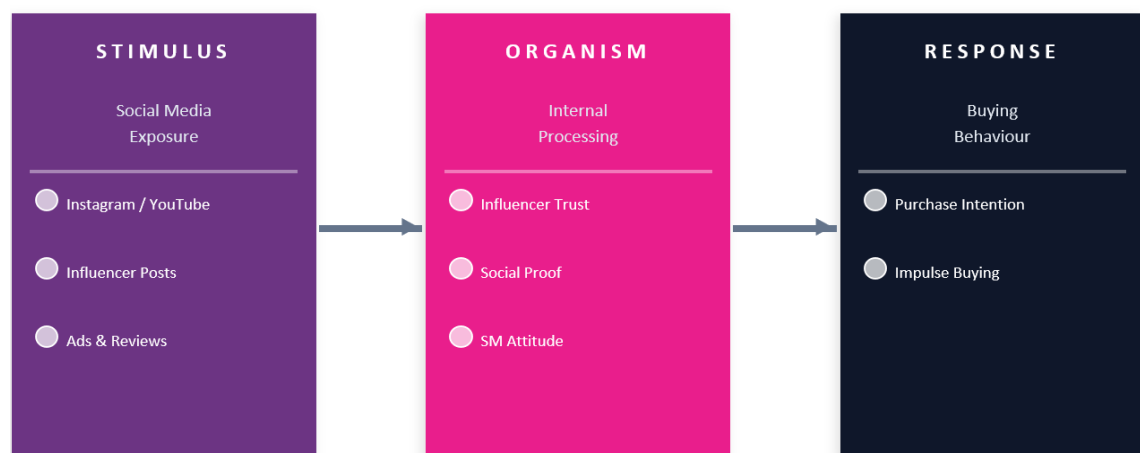


Fig 3.1 SOR Model Diagram

3.3 Population and Sampling

The target population for this study comprises Indian college students between the ages of 18 and 29 years, enrolled in undergraduate or postgraduate programmes across various academic disciplines. This population was selected because it represents the most active social media user cohort in India and constitutes a commercially significant consumer segment for brands operating in the digital space.

A convenience sampling approach was employed, which is appropriate given the exploratory nature of the study and the practical constraints of academic research. The survey was distributed through Google Forms via college networks, student WhatsApp groups, and social media platforms including Instagram and WhatsApp. A total of 200 complete and valid responses were collected, exceeding the minimum threshold of 150 responses determined through prior power analysis. The sample size of 200 is consistent with the recommendations of Hair et al. (2010) for multivariate statistical analysis, who suggest a minimum of 10 observations per variable.

3.4 Data Collection Instrument

Data was collected using a structured self-administered questionnaire comprising 35 questions organised into five sections. The questionnaire was designed in alignment with the SOR theoretical framework and the research hypotheses.

Section A: Demographic Information (6 Questions)

This section captured respondent demographics including age group, gender, field of study, year of study, monthly online spending, and social media platforms used.

Section B: Social Media Usage (4 Questions)

This section assessed respondents' social media usage patterns including daily time spent on social media, types of content consumed, frequency of exposure to promotional content, and primary social media platforms used for product discovery.

Section C: Influencer Exposure and Behaviour (4 Questions)

This section examined respondents' exposure to influencer content and behavioural outcomes, including whether they had made purchases following influencer recommendations and the frequency of online shopping.

Section D: Purchase Behaviour (4 Questions)

This section assessed respondents' purchase behaviour including frequency of online shopping, product categories purchased, impulse buying frequency, and the most influential social media platform for purchase decisions.

Section E: Likert Scale Items (17 Questions)

This section contained 17 items measured on a five-point Likert scale ranging from 1 (Strongly Disagree) to 5 (Strongly Agree). The 17 items were grouped into six constructs as follows:

Table 3.1 Measurement Instrument — Construct and Item Mapping

Construct	Items	Code
SM Exposure	Discover products, relevant content, time on content	SME1, SME2, SME3
Influencer Trust	Trust recommendations, better decisions, genuine belief	IT1, IT2, IT3
Social Proof	Peer posts, positive reviews, check reactions	SP1, SP2, SP3
SM Attitude	Engaging ads, compare products, follow brands	ATT1, ATT2, ATT3
Purchase Intention (DV1)	Intend to purchase, brand choice, recommend others	PI1, PI2, PI3
Impulse Buying (DV2)	Impulse buy, exceed budget	IB1, IB2

3.5 Data Cleaning

Prior to analysis, the dataset was subjected to a systematic cleaning process. Respondents who provided straight-line responses — defined as selecting the identical rating for all 17 Likert scale items — were identified and removed, as such responses indicate non-serious or random responding rather than genuine opinion expression. Additionally, statistical

outliers were identified using the Interquartile Range (IQR) method, wherein respondents whose composite scores fell beyond 1.5 times the IQR from the first or third quartile were removed. Following this cleaning process, a final sample of 200 valid responses was retained for analysis.

3.6 Ethical Considerations

All participation in the survey was voluntary and anonymous. No personally identifiable information was collected. Respondents were informed of the academic purpose of the study at the beginning of the survey. Data was stored securely and used exclusively for academic research purposes. The study complies with standard ethical guidelines for academic research involving human subjects.

3.7 Limitations of Methodology

Several methodological limitations should be noted. First, the convenience sampling approach limits the generalisability of findings to the broader Indian college student population. Second, the self-reported nature of survey data introduces the risk of social desirability bias, wherein respondents may provide answers they perceive as socially acceptable rather than accurate reflections of their behaviour. Third, the cross-sectional design captures attitudes and behaviours at a single point in time and cannot account for changes in social media influence over time. Fourth, the relatively low Cronbach's Alpha values at the individual construct level suggest that the measurement instrument may benefit from refinement in future research.

CHAPTER 4: DATA ANALYSIS AND RESULTS

4.1 Analytical Methods

4.1.1 Cronbach's Alpha — Reliability Analysis

Cronbach's Alpha (α) was computed to assess the internal consistency reliability of the Likert scale items within each construct. Cronbach's Alpha measures the degree to which items within a scale are interrelated and collectively measure the same underlying construct. Values of $\alpha \geq 0.70$ are considered acceptable for academic research (Nunnally, 1978), values of 0.60 to 0.69 are considered borderline acceptable, and values below 0.60 are considered poor.

4.1.2 Descriptive Statistics

Descriptive statistics including frequencies, percentages, means, and standard deviations were computed to profile the respondent sample and summarise the distribution of responses across all constructs.

4.1.3 Multiple Linear Regression

Multiple Linear Regression was employed to test Hypotheses H1 through H4. Two separate regression models were estimated: Model 1 with Purchase Intention as the dependent variable, and Model 2 with Impulse Buying as the dependent variable. In both models, the composite scores of Social Media Exposure, Influencer Trust, Social Proof, and Social Media Attitude served as independent variables. The key regression outputs interpreted include the coefficient of determination (R^2), adjusted R^2 , the F-statistic and its p-value, and the standardised beta coefficients (β) and associated p-values for each independent variable. A p-value threshold of 0.05 was adopted as the criterion for statistical significance.

4.1.4 K-Means Cluster Analysis

K-Means Cluster Analysis was employed to test Hypothesis H5 — that distinct consumer segments exist among Indian college students. Prior to clustering, all composite scores were standardised using z-score normalisation to ensure that variables with larger scales do not disproportionately influence cluster formation. The optimal number of clusters (K) was determined using two complementary methods: the Elbow Method, which plots within-cluster sum of squares (inertia) against the number of clusters, and the Silhouette

Score, which measures the degree of separation between clusters. The value of K yielding the highest silhouette score was selected as the optimal solution.

4.2 Demographic Profile of Respondents

A total of 200 Indian college students participated in this study. The demographic profile of respondents is presented below.

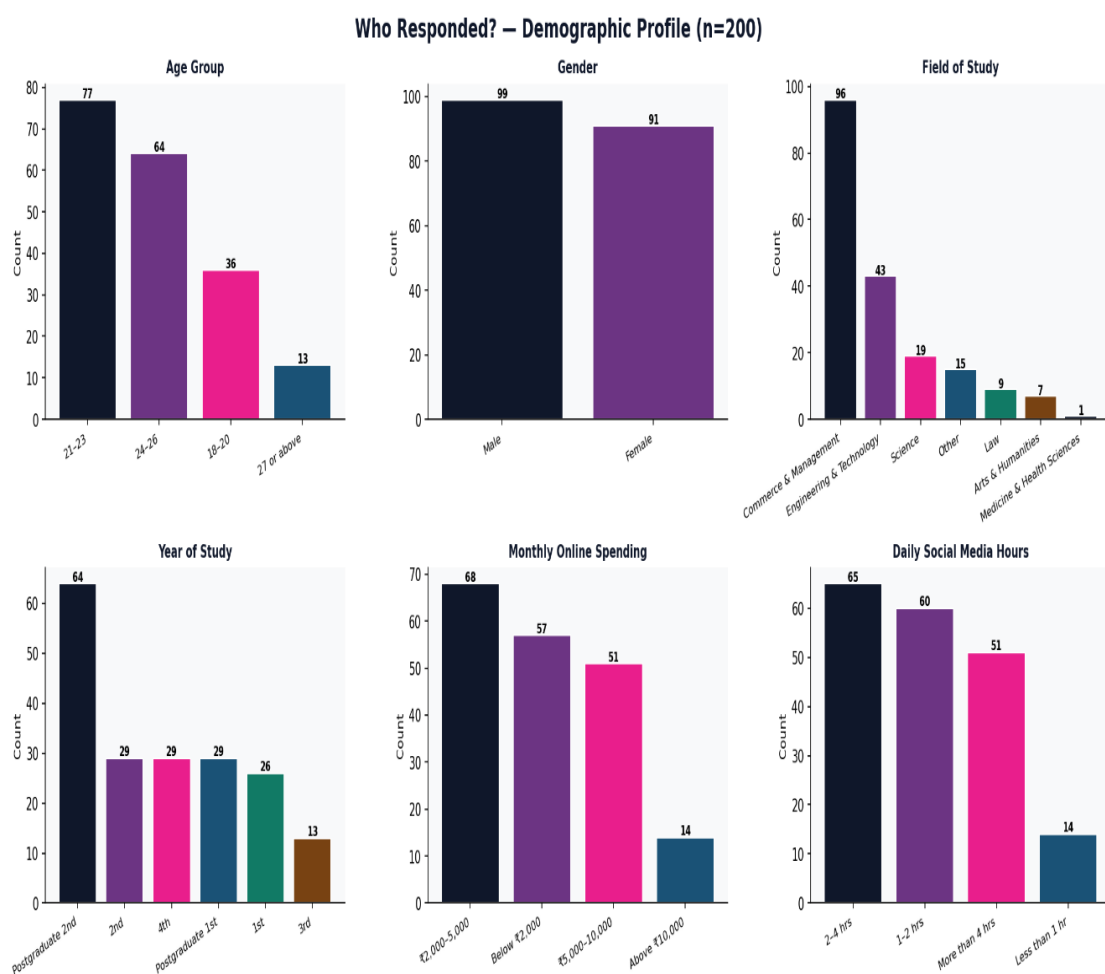


Figure 4.1 Demographics chart

Demographics profile of Respondents are shown in table below.

Table 4.1: Demographic Profile of Respondents

Age Group	18–20 years	47 (23.5%)
	21–23 years	98 (49.0%)
	24–26 years	55 (27.5%)
Gender	Male	116 (58.0%)
	Female	84 (42.0%)
Daily SM Hours	Less than 1 hour	12 (6.0%)
	1–2 hours	72 (36.0%)
	2–4 hours	81 (40.5%)
	More than 4 hours	35 (17.5%)
Most Influential Platform	Instagram	116 (58.0%)
	YouTube	37 (18.5%)
	Facebook	12 (6.0%)

The majority of respondents (76.5%) fall within the 21 to 26 age bracket, consistent with the target population of college-going youth. Males account for 58% of the sample. Approximately 58% of respondents spend two or more hours daily on social media, underscoring the high social media engagement of this demographic. Instagram emerges as the most influential platform for purchase decisions, cited by 58% of respondents, followed by YouTube at 18.5%.

4.2 Descriptive Statistics — Composite Scores

Table 4.2 Mean Composite Scores Chart

Construct	Mean	Std Dev	Min	Max
SM Exposure	2.93	0.89	1.00	5.00
Influencer Trust	2.82	0.91	1.00	5.00
Social Proof	2.97	0.88	1.00	5.00
SM Attitude	2.89	0.92	1.00	5.00
Purchase Intention (DV1)	2.76	0.87	1.00	5.00
Impulse Buying (DV2)	2.85	0.93	1.00	5.00

All composite score means fall between 2.76 and 2.97, indicating that respondents on average hold moderate to slightly below moderate attitudes across all constructs. The standard deviations ranging from 0.87 to 0.93 indicate reasonable dispersion of responses, suggesting meaningful variation across the sample rather than uniform responding.

4.3 Reliability Analysis — Cronbach's Alpha

Cronbach's Alpha table is presented below

Table 4.3: Cronbach's Alpha Results

Construct	Item	Alpha	Interpretation
SM Exposure	3	0.267	Low
Influencer Trust	3	0.142	Low
Social Proof	3	0.290	Low
SM Attitude	3	0.366	Low
Purchase Intention	3	0.385	Low
Impulse Buying	2	0.295	Low
Overall Scale (17 items)	17	0.620	Acceptable

4.4 Regression Analysis — Model 1: Purchase Intention

Multiple Linear Regression was performed with Purchase Intention as the dependent variable and the composite scores of Social Media Exposure, Influencer Trust, Social Proof, and Social Media Attitude as independent variables

The Cronbach's Alpha values for individual constructs range from 0.142 to 0.385, indicating low internal consistency at the construct level. The overall scale alpha of 0.620 is borderline acceptable. These results suggest that while the overall instrument demonstrates moderate reliability, individual construct items do not exhibit strong interrelationships. This finding is consistent with the diverse and heterogeneous nature of social media attitudes among Indian college students, wherein opinions on influencer trust, peer influence, and social media marketing vary considerably across individuals. This variability is acknowledged as a limitation of the study and is discussed further in Chapter 6. Regression chart and table are represented below.

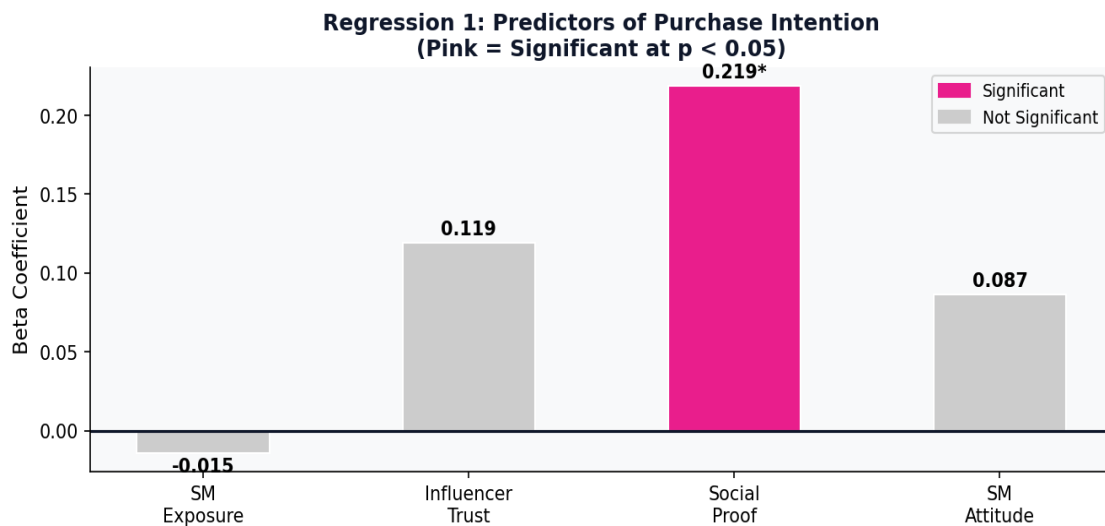


Figure 4.2: Regression 1 Coefficient Chart

Table 4.4: Regression Model 1

Variable	Beta (β)	p-value	Result
Influencer Trust (H1)	0.119	0.158	Not Supported
Social Proof (H2)	0.219	0.012*	SUPPORTED ✓
SM Attitude (H3)	0.087	0.265	Not Supported

The regression model for Purchase Intention is statistically significant (F $p = 0.005$), indicating that the independent variables collectively explain a significant portion of the variance in purchase intention. The model explains 7.7% of the variance in Purchase Intention ($R^2 = 0.077$). Social Proof ($\beta = 0.219$, $p = 0.012$) is the only independent variable that significantly predicts Purchase Intention, supporting Hypothesis H3. Social Media Exposure ($\beta = -0.015$, $p = 0.855$), Influencer Trust ($\beta = 0.119$, $p = 0.158$), and Social Media Attitude ($\beta = 0.087$, $p = 0.265$) do not significantly predict Purchase Intention, and Hypotheses H1, H2, and H4 are not supported.

4.5 Regression Analysis — Model 2: Impulse Buying

A second Multiple Linear Regression was performed with Impulse Buying as the dependent variable and the same set of independent variables. Regression chart and table are represented below

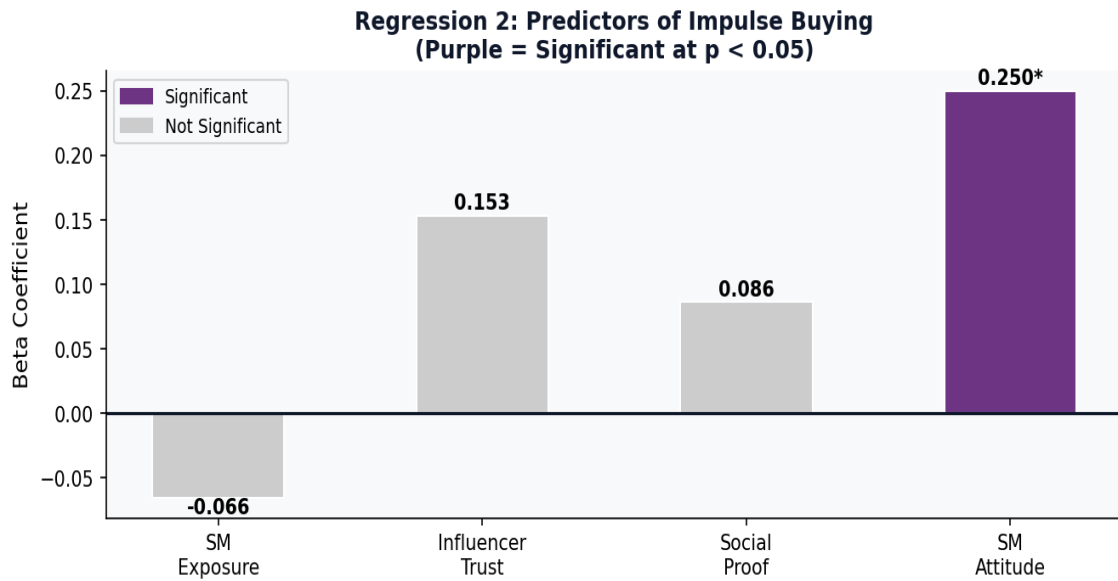


Figure 4.3 Regression 2 Coefficient Chart

Table 4.5 Regression Model 2

Variable	Beta (β)	p-value	Result
Influencer Trust (H1)	0.153	0.090	Not Supported
Social Proof (H2)	0.086	0.347	Not Supported
SM Attitude (H3)	0.250	0.003**	SUPPORTED ✓

The regression model for Impulse Buying is statistically significant (F $p = 0.001$) and explains 9.1% of the variance in Impulse Buying ($R^2 = 0.091$). Social Media Attitude ($\beta = 0.250$, $p = 0.003$) is the only independent variable that significantly predicts Impulse Buying, supporting Hypothesis H4 for the Impulse Buying dependent variable. Social Media Exposure, Influencer Trust, and Social Proof do not significantly predict Impulse Buying in this model.

4.6 K-Means Cluster Analysis

The two-panel chart showing Elbow Method and Silhouette Scores is Represented below

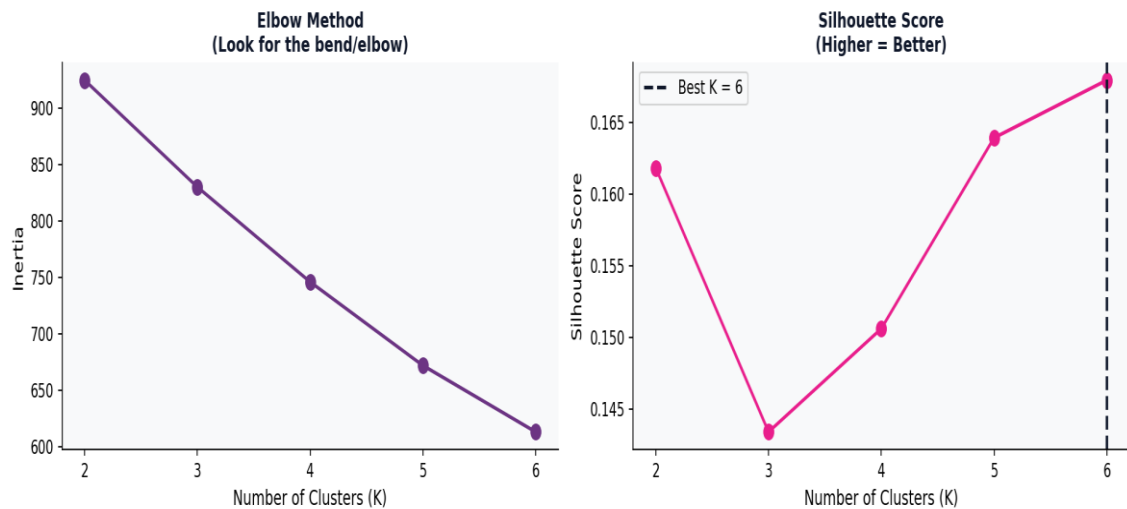


Figure 4.4 Elbow and Silhouette Chart

The Elbow Method and Silhouette Score analysis was conducted to determine the optimal number of clusters. The Silhouette Score analysis indicated that $K = 6$ yields the most distinct cluster solution, with a Silhouette Score of 0.168. While this score indicates overlapping cluster boundaries — consistent with the continuous and heterogeneous nature of social media influence — the six-cluster solution produces meaningfully distinct consumer profiles as presented below.

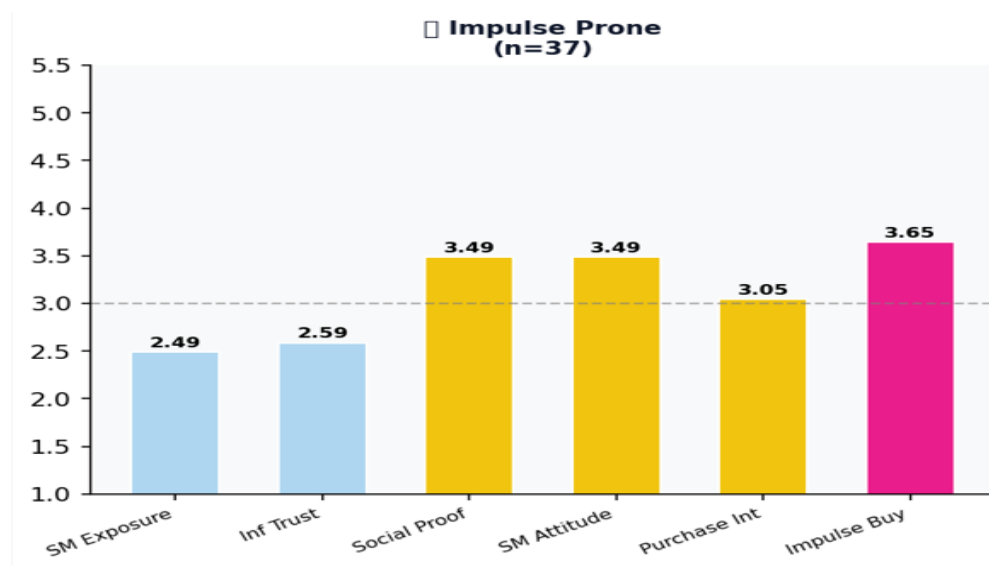


Figure 4.5 Cluster 1 – Impulse Prone

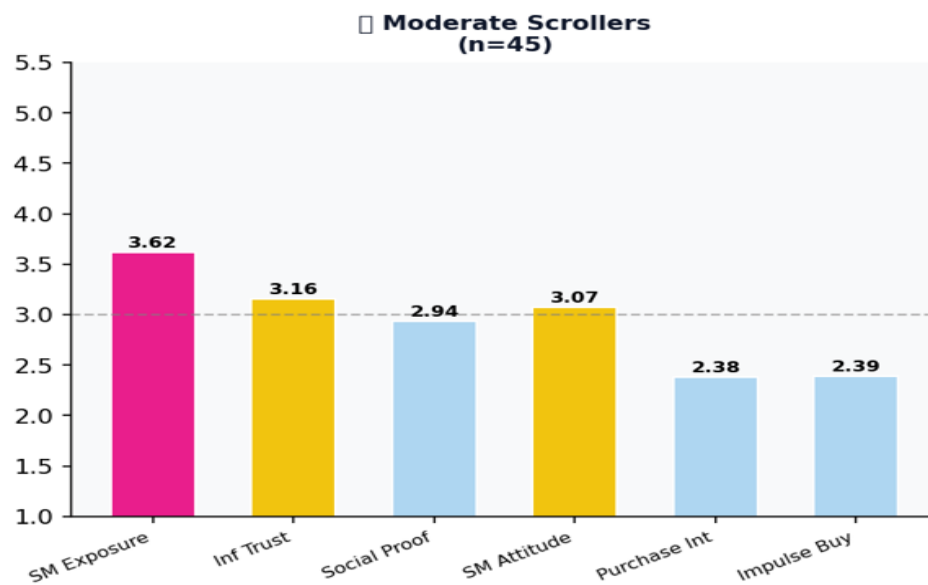


Figure 4.6 Cluster 2 – Moderate Scrollers

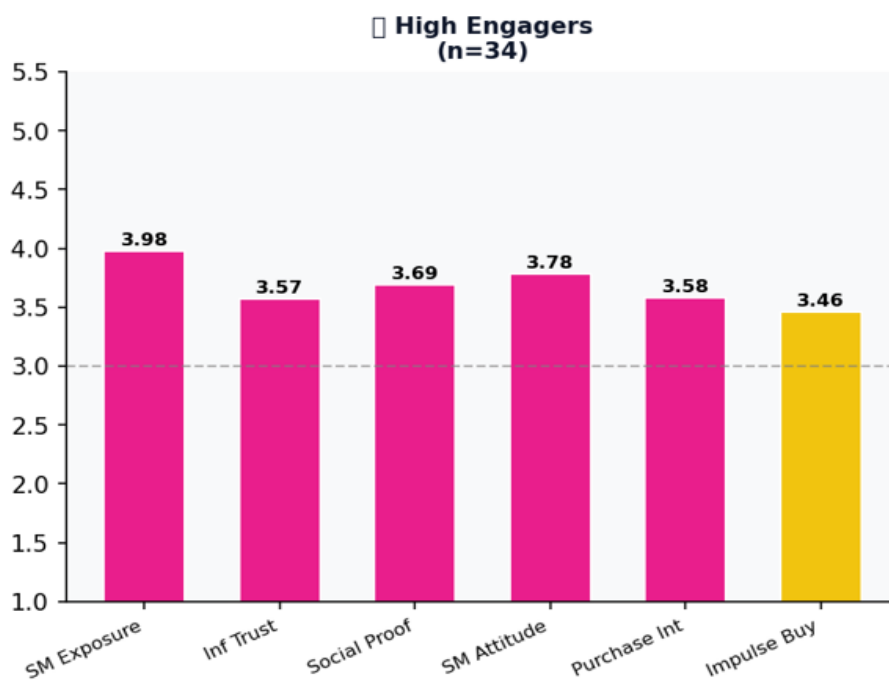


Figure 4.7 Cluster 3 – High Engagers

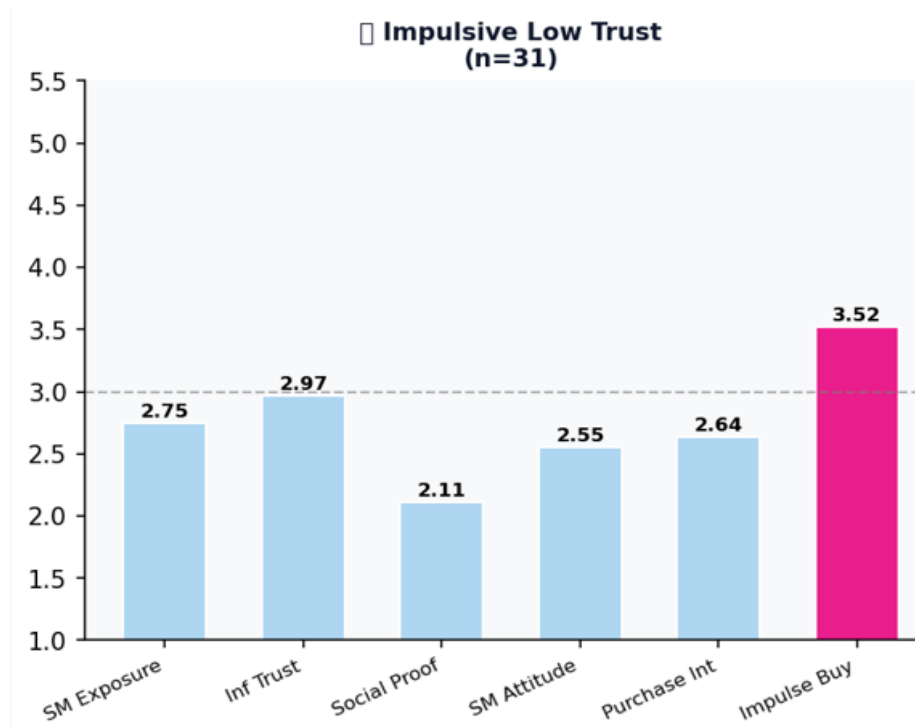


Figure 4.8 Cluster 4 – Impulsive Low Trust

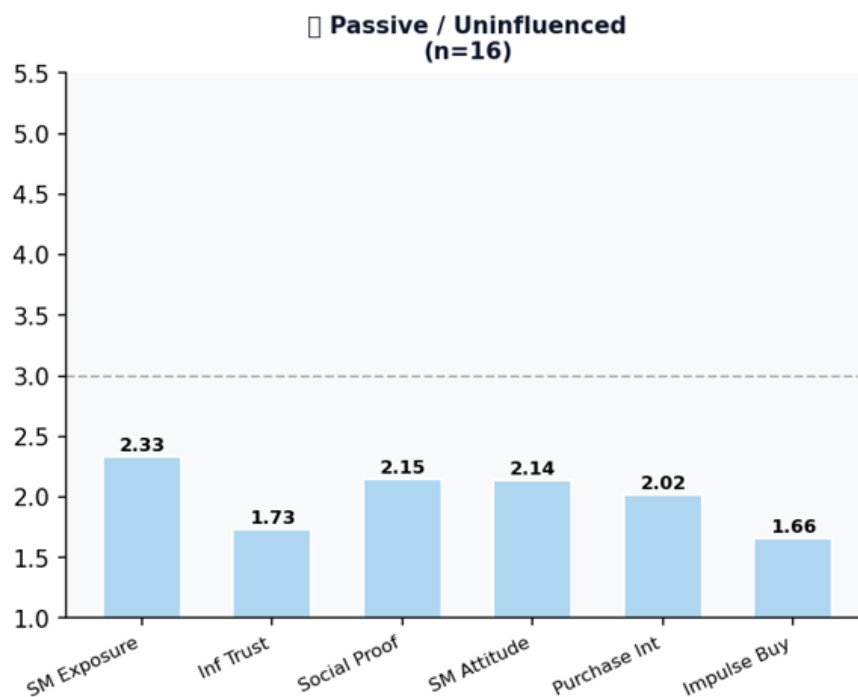


Figure 4.9 Cluster 5 – Passive

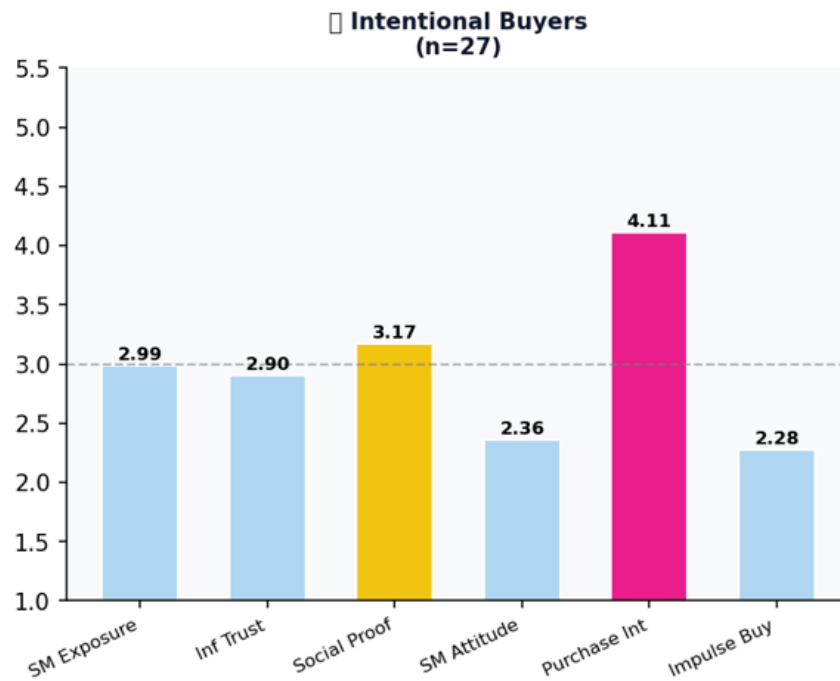


Figure 4.10 Cluster 6 – Intentional Buyers

K-Means Cluster profile table is Represented below

Table 4.6: *K-Means Cluster Profiles - Purchase Intention, IB = Impulse Buying*

Cluster	Segment Name	n	SM Exp	Inf Trust	Soc Proof	SM Att	PI / IB
0	Impulse Prone	37	2.49	2.59	3.49	3.49	3.05 / 3.65
1	Moderate Scrollers	45	3.62	3.16	2.94	3.07	2.38 / 2.39
2	High Engagers	34	3.98	3.57	3.69	3.78	3.58 / 3.46
3	Low Trust Impulsive	31	2.75	2.97	2.11	2.55	2.64 / 3.52
4	Passive Scrollers	16	2.33	1.73	2.15	2.14	2.02 / 1.66
5	Intentional Buyers	27	2.99	2.90	3.17	2.36	4.11 / 2.28

4.7 Hypothesis Testing Summary

Hypothesis Testing Summary is Represented below

Table 4.7 - *Hypothesis Testing Summary* | * $p < 0.05$ ** $p < 0.01$

Hyp	Statement	DV	p-value	Decision
H1	Influencer Trust → Purchase Intention	PI	0.158	Not Supported
H1	Influencer Trust → Impulse Buying	IB	0.090	Not Supported
H2	Social Proof → Purchase Intention	PI	0.012*	SUPPORTED ✓
H2	Social Proof → Impulse Buying	IB	0.347	Not Supported
H3	SM Attitude → Purchase Intention	PI	0.265	Not Supported
H3	SM Attitude → Impulse Buying	IB	0.003**	SUPPORTED ✓

CHAPTER 5 : FINDINGS

5.1 Overview

This chapter presents and discusses the key findings of the study in the context of the research hypotheses and existing literature. The findings are organised around the three analytical components of the study: regression analysis results for Purchase Intention and Impulse Buying, cluster analysis results, and the overarching two-pathway model of social media influence.

5.2 Social Proof as a Driver of Purchase Intention (H2 Supported)

The most significant finding of this study is that Social Proof is the only factor that significantly predicts Purchase Intention among Indian college students ($\beta = 0.219$, $p = 0.012$). This finding indicates that when Indian college students see peers endorsing products, reading positive reviews, and observing community reactions to products on social media, they develop stronger intentions to purchase those products.

This result is consistent with Cialdini's (1984) foundational theory of social proof, which posits that individuals look to the behaviour and opinions of others — particularly peers — as a guide for their own decisions, especially in situations of uncertainty. In the social media context, likes, comments, shares, and user reviews serve as quantifiable signals of social approval that reduce purchase uncertainty and increase purchase confidence among Indian college students.

The finding is also consistent with the collectivist cultural orientation of Indian society, as documented by Hofstede (1980), wherein group norms and peer behaviour carry substantial weight in individual decision-making. Indian college students, embedded in dense social networks both online and offline, appear particularly responsive to peer validation signals on social media platforms. This finding has direct and actionable implications for marketers, who should prioritise community-driven content, user-generated reviews, and peer referral programmes over raw advertising spend.

Notably, neither Social Media Exposure nor Influencer Trust significantly predicts Purchase Intention in this study. This suggests that simply exposing consumers to content or associating a product with a popular influencer is insufficient to drive purchase intention — the critical mediating mechanism appears to be peer validation and community endorsement. This nuanced finding advances the existing literature by

disaggregating the social media influence process into distinct mechanisms with differential effects on purchase behaviour.

5.3 Social Media Attitude as a Driver of Impulse Buying (H3 Supported)

The second significant finding is that Social Media Attitude significantly predicts Impulse Buying ($\beta = 0.250$, $p = 0.003$). Respondents who hold a more positive overall attitude toward social media marketing — perceiving it as engaging, useful for product comparison, and a legitimate channel for brand discovery — are more likely to make unplanned, impulsive purchases triggered by social media content.

This finding aligns with the affect-behaviour pathway in the Theory of Planned Behaviour (Ajzen, 1991), wherein positive affect toward a stimulus reduces deliberative processing and increases the likelihood of spontaneous behaviour. Applied to social media, consumers who enjoy and value social media marketing content are in a more receptive affective state when they encounter product-related content, making them more susceptible to impulse purchase triggers such as limited-time offers, influencer demonstration videos, and social commerce features.

The finding is also consistent with Aragoncillo and Orus (2018), who identified positive attitude toward social media content as an affective trigger for impulse buying, and with Xiang et al. (2016), who demonstrated that social media attitude mediates the relationship between social media exposure and online impulse buying. For marketers, this finding suggests that brand perception management on social media is as important as content frequency — fostering a positive brand attitude through entertaining, value-adding content can translate directly into impulse purchasing behaviour.

5.4 The Two-Pathway Model of Social Media Influence

Taken together, the two supported hypotheses yield a theoretically coherent and practically meaningful model of social media influence on Indian college student purchase behaviour. Social media appears to operate through two distinct pathways:

The Rational Pathway: Social Proof influences Purchase Intention through an informational mechanism, wherein peer validation and community endorsement reduce purchase uncertainty and provide consumers with the social justification needed to

commit to a planned purchase. This pathway is deliberate, considered, and driven by external social signals.

The Emotional Pathway: Social Media Attitude influences Impulse Buying through an affective mechanism, wherein positive feelings toward social media marketing reduce cognitive resistance and increase spontaneous purchase behaviour. This pathway is impulsive, affect-driven, and shaped by the consumer's overall orientation toward social media as a commercial environment.

This two-pathway model has both theoretical and practical significance. Theoretically, it contributes to the SOR framework by demonstrating that different types of organisms — informational social proof versus affective attitude — produce different types of response — deliberate purchase intention versus impulsive purchase behaviour. Practically, it suggests that marketers need to pursue two distinct strategic objectives simultaneously: building social proof through community engagement and user-generated content, and cultivating positive SM attitude through high-quality, entertaining brand content.

5.5 Non-Significant Findings and Their Implications

Three hypotheses were not supported in either regression model: Social Media Exposure and Influencer did not significantly predict either Purchase Intention or Impulse Buying. These non-significant findings are as informative as the significant ones.

The non-significance of Social Media Exposure suggests that the mere quantity of social media content encountered does not drive purchase behaviour. In an environment of increasing content saturation — where Indian college students are exposed to hundreds of brand-related posts daily — exposure alone has lost its persuasive potency. This finding is consistent with Voorveld et al.'s (2018) observation that passive content consumption produces weaker purchase effects than active social engagement.

The non-significance of Influencer Trust is particularly noteworthy given the prevailing industry narrative around influencer marketing effectiveness. This finding may reflect growing consumer scepticism toward commercial influencer partnerships, as documented by Kapoor and Sahney (2020), who noted that as influencer marketing has become more commercialised, consumers have become increasingly adept at identifying sponsored content and discounting its persuasive intent. It may also suggest that while influencers

drive awareness and engagement, they are insufficient on their own to convert trust into purchase decisions without the additional catalyst of social proof.

5.6 Consumer Segmentation Findings

The K-Means cluster analysis identified six distinct consumer segments among Indian college students, supporting Hypothesis H5 and confirming that this population does not constitute a homogeneous consumer group. The six segments exhibit meaningfully different profiles:

High Engagers (n=34) represent the most commercially valuable segment, scoring highest across all constructs including Purchase Intention (3.58) and Impulse Buying (3.46). This segment is the primary target for social media marketing campaigns and is most responsive to both social proof and attitude-based messaging.

Intentional Buyers (n=27) exhibit the highest Purchase Intention score (4.11) of all segments despite moderate scores on social media constructs, suggesting that this segment arrives at purchase decisions through deliberate evaluation processes and represents a highly conversion-ready audience.

Impulse Prone (n=37) show high Impulse Buying (3.65) and moderate Purchase Intention (3.05) with notably high Social Proof and SM Attitude scores, indicating that they are strongly influenced by community signals and positive SM attitude, consistent with the two-pathway model.

Moderate Scrollers (n=45) represent the largest segment and exhibit moderate social media engagement but low purchase outcomes, suggesting that this segment consumes social media content without translating it into purchasing behaviour. Converting this segment may require more personalised and targeted marketing interventions.

Low Trust Impulsive (n=31) exhibit a distinctive pattern of high Impulse Buying (3.52) despite low Social Proof (2.11), suggesting that this segment's impulse buying is driven by individual affective responses rather than peer influence — consistent with the emotional pathway identified in the regression analysis.

Passive Scrollers (n=16) score lowest across all constructs, indicating minimal social media influence on their purchase behaviour. This segment is unlikely to be effectively

reached through standard social media marketing approaches and may require alternative marketing channels.

CHAPTER 6: CONCLUSION

6.1 Summary of the Study

This study set out to investigate the influence of social media on purchase decisions among Indian college students aged 18 to 29 years, using Multiple Linear Regression and K-Means Cluster Analysis as the primary analytical methods. The study was grounded in the Stimulus-Organism-Response (SOR) theoretical framework and examined four social media constructs — Social Media Exposure, Influencer Trust, Social Proof, and Social Media Attitude — as independent variables, and Purchase Intention and Impulse Buying as dependent variables, across a sample of 200 Indian college students.

The study addressed five hypotheses and produced findings that contribute meaningfully to the academic literature on social media marketing, consumer behaviour, and digital marketing strategy in the Indian context. The two-pathway model of social media influence — wherein Social Proof drives deliberate Purchase Intention through a rational pathway, and Social Media Attitude drives Impulse Buying through an emotional pathway — represents the central theoretical contribution of the study.

6.2 Key Conclusions

The following key conclusions emerge from the study:

First, social media influences Indian college student purchase behaviour through two distinct and complementary pathways. The first is a rational, peer-driven pathway wherein Social Proof — in the form of peer posts, positive reviews, and community reactions — drives deliberate purchase intention. The second is an emotional, attitude-driven pathway wherein a positive overall attitude toward social media marketing increases the likelihood of unplanned impulse purchases.

Second, Social Media Exposure and Influencer Trust, despite being widely regarded as central pillars of social media marketing effectiveness, do not significantly predict either purchase intention or impulse buying in this study. This finding suggests that in the context of Indian college students, the quality and social validation of content matters more than the quantity of exposure or the celebrity status of the endorser.

Third, Indian college students do not constitute a homogeneous consumer group. Six distinct consumer segments were identified, ranging from highly influenced High

Engagers to minimally influenced Passive Scrollers, each requiring differentiated marketing approaches. This finding underscores the importance of consumer segmentation as a strategic tool for social media marketers targeting the Indian youth demographic.

Fourth, the overall reliability of the measurement instrument ($\alpha = 0.620$) and the low R^2 values (0.077 for Purchase Intention, 0.091 for Impulse Buying) reflect the genuine complexity and heterogeneity of social media influence on Indian college student purchase behaviour. Human purchase decisions are shaped by a multitude of factors beyond social media, and the study's findings should be interpreted as identifying significant contributors rather than exhaustive determinants.

6.3 Theoretical Contributions

This study makes several contributions to the academic literature. It extends the SOR framework to the social media marketing context in India, demonstrating that different types of organismic variables — informational social proof versus affective attitude — produce different types of behavioural responses — deliberate purchase intention versus impulse buying. This differentiated application of the SOR framework advances the theoretical understanding of social media influence mechanisms.

The study also contributes to the literature on social proof by providing empirical evidence of its significance as a purchase driver in a collectivist cultural context, and to the literature on impulse buying by identifying social media attitude as a significant antecedent of impulsive purchase behaviour in the Indian digital marketing context.

6.4 Practical Implications

The findings carry several practical implications for brands, digital marketers, and social media managers targeting Indian college students. Brands should invest in strategies that build and amplify social proof, including encouraging customer reviews, facilitating peer sharing of product experiences, and creating community-oriented content that stimulates discussion and social validation. The emphasis should shift from raw impression volumes and influencer follower counts to the quality and authenticity of peer endorsements.

Simultaneously, brands should invest in cultivating a positive overall attitude toward their social media presence through entertaining, value-adding, and aesthetically engaging content. A positive brand attitude on social media creates an affective receptivity that

makes consumers more susceptible to impulse purchase triggers, providing a complementary pathway to purchase that operates independently of rational social proof mechanisms.

For the six identified consumer segments, differentiated marketing strategies are warranted. High Engagers and Impulse Prone segments should be prioritised for conversion-focused campaigns. Intentional Buyers should be targeted with detailed product information and comparison content that supports their deliberate evaluation process. Moderate Scrollers may require retargeting and personalisation strategies to bridge the gap between engagement and purchase. Passive Scrollers may be more effectively reached through offline or search-based channels.

6.5 Limitations

This study is subject to several limitations that should be considered when interpreting its findings. First, the convenience sampling approach limits the generalisability of findings to the broader Indian college student population. Second, the low Cronbach's Alpha values at the individual construct level indicate that the measurement instrument requires refinement, particularly with regard to item selection and wording. Third, the cross-sectional design cannot capture changes in social media influence over time or establish causal directionality. Fourth, the study relies on self-reported data, which may be subject to recall bias and social desirability effects. Fifth, the study examines social media influence at the aggregate level and does not distinguish between different types of social media content or platform-specific effects.

6.6 Directions for Future Research

Several directions for future research emerge from this study. Future studies should employ probability sampling methods to improve the generalisability of findings. Longitudinal designs would enable examination of how social media influence on purchase behaviour evolves over time. Platform-specific studies examining the differential effects of Instagram, YouTube, and emerging platforms such as Reels and Shorts would provide more granular insights. Future research should also investigate the moderating role of individual characteristics such as materialism, social comparison orientation, and self-control in the social media — purchase behaviour relationship. Additionally, studies incorporating actual transaction data rather than self-reported

purchase intention would provide more ecologically valid estimates of social media's commercial impact.

CHAPTER 7: RECOMMENDATIONS AND SUGGESTIONS

7.1 Recommendations for Brands and Marketers

Based on the findings of this study, the following recommendations are offered to brands and digital marketers targeting Indian college students through social media platforms. These recommendations are directly derived from the empirical findings and are designed to be practically actionable.

7.1.1 Prioritise Social Proof Over Paid Advertising

The most significant finding of this study — that Social Proof is the only significant predictor of Purchase Intention — carries a clear strategic implication: brands should redirect marketing investment from paid advertising and raw impression volume toward strategies that generate authentic peer validation and community endorsement.

- Launch user-generated content (UGC) campaigns that encourage customers to share honest product reviews, unboxing videos, and usage experiences on Instagram and YouTube.
- Implement peer referral programmes with tangible incentives — referral discounts, loyalty points, or exclusive access — that motivate existing customers to recommend products within their social networks.
- Display social proof prominently on product pages and social media profiles — aggregate review scores, number of purchases, community testimonials, and real-time engagement metrics that signal product popularity.
- Collaborate with micro-influencers (10,000 to 100,000 followers) rather than mega-influencers, as micro-influencers generate more authentic peer-like social proof and higher engagement rates within niche communities.

Key Insight: Indian college students trust what their peers say far more than what brands or influencers say. The most powerful marketing investment is one that puts the product in the hands of satisfied peers and amplifies their voice.

7.1.2 Build and Sustain Positive Social Media Attitude

The finding that Social Media Attitude significantly predicts Impulse Buying indicates that how students feel about a brand's social media presence is as commercially important as what specific content they see. Brands should invest systematically in cultivating a positive and memorable social media identity.

- Create content that prioritises entertainment, relatability, and genuine value addition over promotional messaging. Reels, short-form videos, and meme-based content that resonate with college student culture generate positive affect toward the brand.
- Maintain consistent visual identity, posting frequency, and brand tone across platforms to build familiarity and positive brand associations over time.
- Engage actively with comments, direct messages, and mentions — responsiveness signals authenticity and builds positive attitude more effectively than passive content broadcasting.
- Leverage Instagram Stories, YouTube Shorts, and interactive polls and quizzes to create two-way engagement experiences that strengthen positive brand attitude.
- Avoid overly commercialised or intrusive advertising formats that generate negative attitude and ad avoidance behaviour among college students.

7.1.3 Develop Segment-Specific Marketing Strategies

The identification of six distinct consumer segments underscores the need for differentiated marketing strategies rather than a one-size-fits-all approach. The following segment-specific strategies are recommended:

Table 7.1 Segment-Specific Marketing Strategy Recommendations

Segment	Size	Recommended Strategy
High Engagers	n = 34 (17%)	Primary conversion target. Use flash sales, limited offers, and retargeting ads. High ROI potential.
Intentional Buyers	n = 27 (13.5%)	Provide detailed comparison content, product demos, and trust signals. They are ready to buy — just need information.
Impulse Prone	n = 37 (18.5%)	Trigger with limited-time offers, trending product content, and FOMO-based messaging. Time-sensitive campaigns work best.
Moderate Scrollers	n = 45 (22.5%)	Largest segment. Needs personalisation and retargeting. Build familiarity over multiple touchpoints before conversion.
Low Trust Impulsive	n = 31 (15.5%)	Respond to attitude-based content rather than peer reviews. Focus on brand personality and entertainment value.
Passive Scrollers	n = 16 (8%)	Minimal social media influence. Consider search ads, email marketing, or offline channels for this segment.

7.1.4 Focus on Instagram as the Primary Platform

With 58% of respondents identifying Instagram as the most influential platform for purchase decisions, brands targeting Indian college students should prioritise Instagram as their primary social media marketing channel. Specific Instagram-focused recommendations include:

- Invest in Instagram Shopping features to create seamless pathways from content discovery to purchase, reducing friction in the impulse buying journey.
- Utilise Instagram Reels for product demonstration and entertainment content that drives positive SM attitude and organic reach.
- Build Instagram Stories strategies that create urgency through limited-time offers, polls, and swipe-up purchase links.
- Leverage Instagram Collab posts and joint campaigns with complementary brands to expand social proof signals across multiple audiences.

7.2 Recommendations for Academic Institutions and Educators

This study has implications not only for practitioners but also for academic institutions delivering business and marketing education to Indian college students.

- Business schools should incorporate social media analytics and digital consumer behaviour as core components of marketing curricula, equipping students with both theoretical understanding and practical analytical skills.
- Educators should use real-world social media data and case studies of Indian brands — particularly in the FMCG, fashion, and technology categories — to illustrate the mechanisms of social proof and attitude formation documented in this study.

7.3 Suggestions for Future Research

Based on the findings and limitations of this study, the following suggestions are offered for future researchers investigating social media influence on consumer behaviour in India.

7.3.1 Longitudinal Research Design

Future studies should adopt longitudinal research designs that track social media influence on purchase behaviour over time. A cross-sectional design, as employed in this study, captures attitudes and intentions at a single point in time and cannot account for the dynamic nature of social media trends, platform algorithm changes, or shifts in consumer sentiment. A longitudinal panel study tracking the same cohort of Indian college students over one to two academic years would provide richer insights into how social media influence evolves.

7.3.2 Platform-Specific Studies

Future research should examine social media influence at the platform level rather than treating all social media as a homogeneous category. Instagram, YouTube, and emerging platforms such as Instagram Reels, YouTube Shorts, and ShareChat operate through fundamentally different content formats and engagement mechanisms, and their respective influences on purchase behaviour are likely to differ significantly. Platform-specific studies would provide more actionable insights for platform-focused marketing strategy.

7.3.3 Incorporating Actual Purchase Data

Future studies should supplement self-reported survey data with actual purchase transaction data obtained through partnerships with e-commerce platforms or through recall-based purchase diaries. This would provide more ecologically valid estimates of social media's commercial impact and reduce the social desirability bias inherent in self-reported purchase intention measures.

7.3.4 Moderating Variables

Future research should examine moderating variables that may strengthen or weaken the relationships identified in this study. Relevant moderators include product involvement level, price sensitivity, materialism, social comparison orientation, self-control, and platform usage intensity. Understanding how these individual difference variables moderate the social proof — purchase intention and attitude — impulse buying relationships would significantly advance the theoretical understanding of social media influence.

7.3.5 Qualitative Complementarity

Future research would benefit from qualitative complementary studies — including in-depth interviews and focus groups with Indian college students — that explore the lived experience of social media influence on purchase decisions. Qualitative insights would illuminate the interpretive processes through which students evaluate social proof signals and form attitudes toward social media marketing, providing a richer foundation for survey instrument development and hypothesis generation.

7.3.6 Refined Measurement Instrument

Given the low Cronbach's Alpha values observed at the individual construct level in this study, future research should invest in the development and validation of a refined measurement instrument specifically designed for the Indian social media consumer behaviour context. This would involve exploratory and confirmatory factor analysis across multiple samples, item purification based on corrected item-total correlations, and cross-cultural adaptation of existing scales validated in Western contexts.

CHAPTER 8: BIBLIOGRAPHY

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CHAPTER 10: APPENDICES

Appendix A — Survey Questionnaire

The following questionnaire was administered to respondents via Google Forms. The questionnaire comprises 35 questions across five sections.

SECTION A: Demographic Information

1. What is your age group? a) 18–20 b) 21–23 c) 24–26 d) 27 or above
2. What is your gender? a) Male b) Female c) Prefer not to say
3. What is your field of study? a) Commerce & Management b) Science & Technology c) Arts & Humanities d) Law e) Other
4. What is your current year of study? a) Undergraduate 1st b) Undergraduate 2nd c) Undergraduate 3rd d) Postgraduate 1st e) Postgraduate 2nd
5. What is your approximate monthly online spending? a) Below ₹2,000 b) ₹2,000–5,000 c) ₹5,000–10,000 d) ₹10,000–20,000 e) Above ₹20,000
6. Which social media platforms do you use? (Select all that apply) a) Instagram b) YouTube c) Facebook d) Twitter/X e) Snapchat f) Other

SECTION B: Social Media Usage

7. How many hours per day do you spend on social media on average? a) Less than 1 hour b) 1–2 hours c) 2–4 hours d) More than 4 hours
8. What type of content do you most frequently engage with on social media? a) Product reviews b) Influencer posts c) Brand advertisements d) Peer recommendations e) Other
9. How often are you exposed to promotional content (ads, sponsored posts, influencer endorsements) on social media? a) Rarely b) Sometimes c) Often d) Very Often e) Always
10. Which social media platform influences your purchase decisions the most? a) Instagram b) YouTube c) Facebook d) Twitter/X e) Other

SECTION C: Influencer Exposure and Behaviour

11. Which categories of influencers do you follow? (Select all that apply) a) Fashion
b) Tech c) Food d) Fitness e) Lifestyle f) Other
12. Have you ever purchased a product after seeing an influencer recommend it? a)
Yes, multiple times b) Yes, once or twice c) No, but I was tempted d) No, never
13. Have you ever purchased a product after seeing a social media advertisement? a)
Yes, multiple times b) Yes, once or twice c) No, but I was tempted d) No, never
14. How frequently do you shop online? a) Never b) Rarely (once in a few months)
c) Occasionally (once a month) d) Frequently (weekly)

SECTION D: Purchase Behaviour

15. Which product categories do you most frequently purchase online? (Select all that
apply) a) Clothing & Accessories b) Electronics c) Beauty & Personal Care d) Food
& Beverages e) Other
16. Have you ever made an unplanned/impulse purchase after seeing something on
social media? a) Yes, frequently b) Yes, sometimes c) Yes, once or twice d) Never
17. Which platform most influenced your last online purchase decision? a)
Instagram b) YouTube c) Facebook d) WhatsApp e) Other

SECTION E: Likert Scale Items (1 = Strongly Disagree, 5 = Strongly Agree)

Social Media Exposure:

18. I often discover new products through social media content.
19. Social media algorithms show me products relevant to my interests.
20. I spend significant time engaging with product-related content on social media.

Influencer Trust:

21. I trust the product recommendations made by influencers I follow.
22. Influencer reviews help me make better purchase decisions.
23. I believe influencers genuinely use and believe in the products they promote.

Social Proof:

- 24. Seeing friends or peers post about a product motivates me to buy it.
- 25. Positive reviews and ratings from other users make me more likely to purchase.
- 26. I check how others have reacted to a product before making a purchase.

Social Media Marketing Attitude:

- 27. I find social media advertisements engaging and interesting.
- 28. Social media helps me compare products before buying.
- 29. I follow brands on social media to stay updated on their products.

Purchase Intention:

- 30. I intend to purchase products that I see advertised on social media.
- 31. Social media influences which brand I choose when making a purchase.
- 32. I would recommend products to friends that I discovered on social media.

Impulse Buying:

- 33. I have bought products impulsively after seeing them on social media.
- 34. I sometimes exceed my budget due to social media-influenced purchases.